

GE261004 DESIGN THINKING

Unit II – Empathy and Problem Definition · Presentation 1 of 6

Understanding Users and Stakeholders

Why the user is never you · users, customers and gatekeepers · mainstream and extreme users · stakeholder mapping · personas and their limits

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In this presentation

- The user is not you
- Four kinds of people in a project
- Mainstream and extreme users
- Why extremes teach you more
- What a stakeholder map is for
- The power–interest grid
- Building a map in four steps
- Personas, and their limits

1

Who you are designing for

The people behind the problem – and why they are not you

The user is not you

- You know too much: you designed it, so you can always find the button
- You are not typical – your age, education, income and confidence are all unusual
- Designing for yourself works only when you are genuinely the user, and can show it
- Every belief you hold about a user is a hypothesis until somebody checks it

KEY POINT Write your assumptions down before you go out. Field work is how you find out which of them were wrong.

Four kinds of people in every project

The user

Uses the thing, every day. Lives with every decision you made, including the ones you never noticed making.

The customer

Pays for it. A parent, a hospital, a department – often someone who never touches the product.

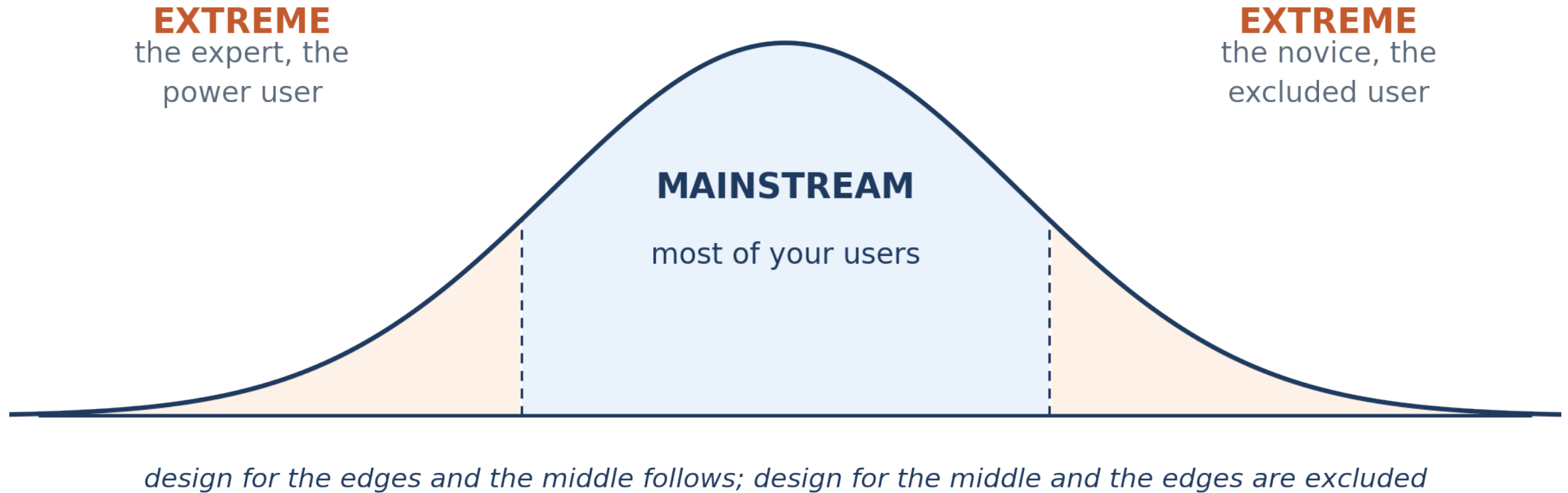
The gatekeeper

Decides whether it may be used at all: a regulator, an IT department, a head of the family.

The influencer

Shapes the decision without making it: a shopkeeper, a senior colleague, a neighbour who already owns one.

Mainstream and extreme users



The two tails are where the design problems show themselves first.

Why extreme users teach you more

- They meet every weakness in the design, and they meet it sooner and harder
- They have already invented workarounds – free design research, if you look
- What an extreme user needs is usually what everyone needs, only more visibly
- Both ends count: the expert who pushes the limits, the novice who cannot begin

KEY POINT Interview three extreme users before you interview thirty average ones. You will learn more in less time.

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Stakeholder mapping

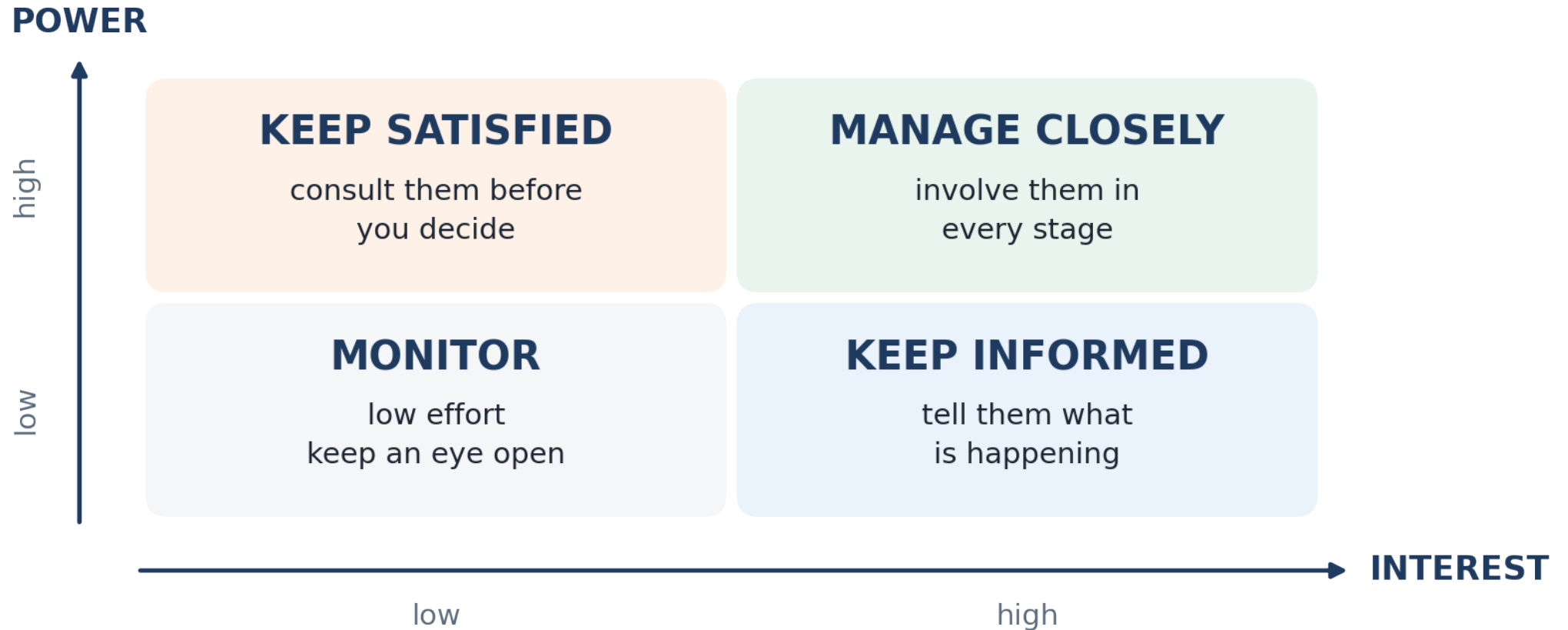
Everyone who can help you – and everyone who can stop you

What a stakeholder map is for

- Lists everyone affected, not only the person sitting in front of you
- Shows who must be consulted, who must be told, and who can simply say no
- Surfaces conflict early, when different groups want incompatible things
- Tells you whom to interview, and in what order

KEY POINT Projects fail far more often on a stakeholder nobody mapped than on a technical problem nobody solved.

The power–interest grid



Place every stakeholder once, then decide what each quadrant needs from you.

Building a map in four steps

- List every person and group the problem touches – go wide before you judge
- Place each on power and interest, and argue the position out loud
- Mark who is missing: who is affected but has no voice in the room?
- Decide one action per quadrant, and write down who is doing it

ACTIVITY Fifteen minutes. Map at least eight stakeholders for your team's problem, and name one you had completely forgotten.

What each quadrant needs from you

Quadrant	Who they are	What you do
Manage closely	High power, high interest	Involve in framing, ideation and testing
Keep satisfied	High power, low interest	Consult before decisions; keep it brief
Keep informed	Low power, high interest	Share progress often; usually your users
Monitor	Low power, low interest	Watch for change; spend no effort yet

Your users usually sit in “low power, high interest” – which is exactly why their needs get overruled.

Personas, and their limits

What a persona gives you

- One named person to design for
- Shared language in the team
- A check on “the user wants...”
- A face to put on the evidence

What it cannot do

- Replace meeting real people
- Make invented detail true
- Cover the edges of the range
- Stay correct without updating

KEY POINT A persona built from field notes is a summary. A persona built from imagination is a stereotype.

THINK ABOUT IT

Who is affected by your team's problem but will never be in the room?

- Who has no time, no money or no standing to attend?
- What would they say if somebody asked them?
- How could you reach even one of them this week?
- What would change in your brief if you did?

Summary

- You are almost never the user; assumptions are hypotheses to test
- User, customer, gatekeeper and influencer are four different people
- Extreme users reveal in three interviews what thirty average ones hide
- A stakeholder map shows who helps, who blocks and who is missing
- The power–interest grid sets the action for each group
- Personas summarise evidence; they never substitute for it

Next: Empathy mapping

- Empathy as evidence, not sympathy
- The gap between what people say and what they do
- The four quadrants: Says, Thinks, Does, Feels
- Pains, gains, and how to read a finished map